

BREASTFEEDING PROMOTION & SUPPORT WPPM #630-12

Subject: Breastfeeding Peer Counseling Program

Item: Peer Counselors: Requirements and Responsibilities

PURPOSE:

To provide information on the Breastfeeding Peer Counseling (BFPC) Program's peer counselor (PC) requirements and responsibilities.

POLICY:

- I. All local agencies (LAs) with a BFPC Program must hire PCs who meet USDA requirements. Refer to Procedures I.
- II. PCs must provide BFPC Program services in one-on-one and group settings for BFPC Program participants, with a goal of increasing breastfeeding initiation, exclusivity, and duration rates.
- III. PCs must be trained by and work under the supervision of the PC Supervisor/ International Board-Certified Lactation Consultant (IBCLC). Refer to WPPM 630-11.

PROCEDURES:

- I. PC Qualifications. PC candidates must:
 - A. Be paraprofessionals (i.e., individuals without extended professional training in health, nutrition, or clinical management of breastfeeding and who are not licensed or credentialed as healthcare, nutrition, or lactation consultant professionals).
 - B. Be enthusiastic about breastfeeding and have a desire to share that enthusiasm.
 - C. Be recruited and hired from the target population.
 - D. Have excellent communication skills.
 - E. Have previous experience with breastfeeding, having breastfed at least one baby.
 - F. Speak the same language as the target population, and to the extent possible, represent the same racial/ethnic background as the participants they support.
- II. PC Responsibilities. PCs must:
 - A. Provide basic breastfeeding information and support to pregnant and breastfeeding participants.
 - B. Counsel pregnant and breastfeeding participants to help avoid and address common breastfeeding problems.
 - C. Maintain regular contact (e.g., telephone, in person, in a hospital, at home, email, text/chat messaging, videoconference, etc.) in accordance with the frequency

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intervals in WPPM 630-13. For virtual contacts, refer to WPPM 220-20 and WPPM 220-30.

- D. Provide support and information to breastfeeding participants who are working or going to school.
- E. Document all counseling contacts and follow procedures for identifying PC participants in the CDPH/WIC approved management information system.
- F. Teach the use, cleaning, and assembly of breast pumps, in addition to expression and storage of human milk as needed.
- G. Clean pumps as needed to meet the needs of participants enrolled in the BFPC Program.
- H. Facilitate prenatal and/or postpartum breastfeeding support groups for BFPC Program participants.
- I. Make immediate referrals to the IBCLC, healthcare professionals, or other community resources, according to the LA's established referral protocol, when they encounter:
 - 1. Breastfeeding problems outside of the normal breastfeeding experience and the PC scope of practice. Refer to *When to Yield: Guidelines for Referring to an IBCLC/HCP/CPA*.
 - 2. Breastfeeding problems that are not resolved within 24-48 hours of their intervention.
 - 3. Problems in an area other than breastfeeding.
- J. Make PC services available outside the usual WIC site environment and usual hours of operation.

AUTHORITY:

USDA Breastfeeding Curriculum

[WIC Breastfeeding Model Components for Peer Counseling](#)

CROSS REFERENCE:

WPPM 220-20 Virtual Breastfeeding Support and Telelactation

WPPM 220-30 Telehealth Privacy and Confidentiality

WPPM 630-11 Peer Counseling Supervisor/IBCLC: Requirements and Responsibilities

WPPM 630-13 Contacts

RESOURCE:

Breastfeeding Peer Counselor (BFPC) Program Guidance Manual

When to Yield: Guidelines for Referring to an IBCLC/HCP/CPA